

Your home care call guide

What to have ready, the questions to ask, and what happens next when a home care agency calls you.



“Keep this next to the phone. Tick things off and jot down the answers as you go.”

STEP 1

Before the call

The first call is usually 15 to 30 minutes. It goes much more smoothly if you have a few things to hand, and if the person who needs care can be part of the conversation where possible.

Have ready

- ☐ A list of medicines, or the boxes and repeat prescription slip
- ☐ The GP surgery's name and phone number
- ☐ Any hospital discharge letter or care plan you already have
- ☐ The times of day help is needed, and roughly how long each time
- ☐ Details of any lasting power of attorney
- ☐ A rough weekly budget, if you're paying privately

Think about

- ☐ Their daily routine, from getting up to going to bed
- ☐ What they can do for themselves, and what they find hard
- ☐ Likes, dislikes, hobbies and what matters most to them
- ☐ How carers will get in: a key safe, a neighbour, family
- ☐ Who else helps now: family, friends, community nurses
- ☐ How soon care needs to start

Your rights, in one line each

- ✓ Anyone who appears to need care can ask the council for a free needs assessment.
- ✓ If you provide care for a family member, you can ask the council for a carer's assessment for yourself.
- ✓ Every home care agency in England must be registered with the Care Quality Commission (CQC).
- ✓ You're never obliged to go ahead with an agency, even after an assessment.

STEP 2

The questions to ask

Tick each one as you ask it. The line underneath explains why it matters.

A The care and the visits

1 Can you cover the visit times we need, including weekends and bank holidays?

Some agencies are full at popular times, especially mornings and bedtime.

2 What's your shortest visit, and how long will the carer actually be with us?

Travel time comes out of some visits. You want the full time with your loved one.

3 How soon could care start?

Important if someone is waiting to come home from hospital.

4 How do carers record each visit, and can the family see the notes?

Many agencies use an app, so you can check a visit happened and how it went.

5 Can you help with medicines, and how do you record it?

Medicine support must be agreed in the care plan and written down every time.

B The carers

6 Will it be the same small group of carers most of the time?

Familiar faces matter, especially for someone living with dementia.

7 How do you introduce a new carer, and can we meet them first?

A good agency won't send a stranger without an introduction.

8 What training do your carers have, including the Care Certificate?

The Care Certificate covers the basics of safe, kind care for new care workers.

9 Are carers paid for their travel time between visits?

Agencies that pay carers properly tend to keep them, so you see the same people.

10 How do you check the quality of care, for example with spot checks?

Managers should visit and check, not just rely on the carer's notes.

C When something goes wrong

11 What happens if a carer is running late or can't come?

Ask how they'll tell you, and how they make sure a visit is never simply missed.

12 Who do we call in the evening or at the weekend?

There should always be someone on call when the office is closed.

13 How do we raise a concern, and who deals with it?

A clear complaints process is a sign of a well run agency.

D Money and contracts

14 Can we have every rate in writing: weekdays, evenings, weekends and bank holidays?

Rates often differ. A written quote makes comparing fair and avoids surprises.

15 Is there a charge for the assessment, or for mileage on shopping trips?

Some costs only appear on the first invoice.

16 How much notice do we need to give to change or stop care?

Check this before signing, in case needs change or someone goes into hospital.

17 Do you work with council-funded care, if the council helps pay?

Not every agency does. Worth knowing if a council assessment is under way.

E Checking the agency

18 What was your last CQC rating, and what has changed since?

Look up any agency on the CQC website. Check the date too, and ask about anything the report raised.

19 How long have you been running, and how many people do you support near us?

Useful context, especially for newer agencies still waiting for a first inspection.

20 Can we speak to you again before we decide?

A good agency will give you time. There should be no pressure to sign on the first call.

Trust your instinct. Did they ask about your loved one as a person: their routines, what they enjoy, what worries them? An agency that listens on the first call is more likely to listen once care begins.

DURING THE CALL

Your notes

Fill this in as you talk, so you have everything in one place when you decide.

Agency name	
Who I spoke to, and the date	
Their phone number and email	
Weekday hourly rate	
Evening and weekend rates	
Bank holiday rate	
Shortest visit	
Any other charges	
Earliest start date	
Latest CQC rating and date	
Notice period	
Assessment booked for	
How they made me feel	
Anything to follow up	

After the call

The assessment visit

Most agencies visit the home before care starts. It often takes around an hour. They'll talk about routines, health, moving around the home and what matters most, and look for anything that could make care harder, such as trip hazards or a bathroom that's difficult to use. It helps if a family member is there, but the conversation should be with the person who needs care as much as possible.

A good care plan includes

- ✓ What carers will do at each visit, in plain words
- ✓ Visit times and how long each one lasts
- ✓ How your loved one likes things done
- ✓ Medicines support, if any, and how it's recorded
- ✓ Who to contact, day and night
- ✓ When the plan will be reviewed

Warning signs

- ! Pressure to sign or pay on the first call
- ! No written quote, or rates that change when you ask
- ! Vague answers about who the carers will be
- ! No out-of-hours number
- ! They can't tell you their CQC rating
- ! They don't ask about the person, only the hours

In the first few weeks

Expect the agency to check in on how things are going. Tell them early if something isn't working, from visit times to how a carer gets on with your loved one. You can ask for a review of the care plan at any time.

Money facts and useful contacts

£34.42 an hour

The Homecare Association minimum price for home care in England, 2026 to 2027. Private prices are usually higher.

£23,250

With savings over this, you'll usually pay the full cost yourself. Between £14,250 and £23,250 the council may help and you contribute.

Your home isn't counted

If care is needed so someone can stay at home, the council's financial assessment doesn't include the home they live in.

£76.70 or £114.60 a week

Attendance Allowance, for people of State Pension age who need help or supervision. It isn't means tested.

Sources: Homecare Association Minimum Price for Homecare 2026 to 2027; GOV.UK social care charging for care and support 2026 to 2027; Age UK financial assessment for care; GOV.UK Attendance Allowance rates (checked 30 September 2026).

Free advice lines

Age UK Advice Line

0800 678 1602

Free, 8am to 7pm, every day of the year

Carers UK Helpline

0808 808 7777

Free, Monday to Friday, 9am to 6pm

Dementia UK Admiral Nurse Helpline

0800 888 6678

Free, Monday to Friday 9am to 9pm, weekends and bank holidays 9am to 5pm

Your council's adult social care team

gov.uk/find-local-council

For a needs assessment, a carer's assessment and help with the cost of care

Care Quality Commission

cqc.org.uk

Look up any agency's rating and latest inspection report

Need to find another agency?

Hello Hattie is a free matching service, not a care provider. Tell us what's needed at **hellohattie.co.uk** and we'll match you with a CQC-registered agency that covers your postcode. Your details go to one agency only, never a list.